

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF NEW YORK

----- X

DEMETRIUS BURKE,

Plaintiff,

**SUMMONS TO THE
VERIFIED COMPLAINT**

-against-

Index:

THE CITY OF NEW YORK; P.O. MICHAEL PENA, Shield # 6176; DET. RICHARD MELEES, Shield # 4478; SGT. SHANNON BROOKS, Tax # 927964, Shield # 1365; UNDERCOVER OFFICER NUMBER 303; and P.O. JOHN DOES # 1-5, the individual defendant(s) sued individually and in their official capacities,

Basis of Venue: occurrence of incident – 109 East 16th Street, New York, New York

Defendants.

----- X

To the above named defendants:

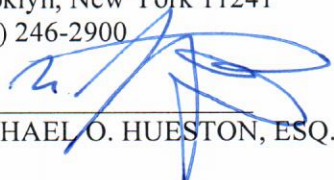
You are hereby summoned to answer the complaint in this action, and to serve a copy of your answer or, if the complaint is not served with this summons, to serve a notice of appearance on the plaintiff's attorney within twenty days after service of this summons exclusive of the day of service where service is made by delivery upon you personally within the state, or within thirty days after completion of service where service is made in any other manner. In case of your failure to appear or answer, judgment will be taken against you by default for the relief demanded in the complaint.

DATED: Brooklyn, New York
June 28, 2017

MICHAEL O. HUESTON, ESQ.
Attorney for Plaintiff

16 Court Street, Suite 3301
Brooklyn, New York 11241
(718) 246-2900

By:


MICHAEL O. HUESTON, ESQ.

Defendants' addresses: THE CITY OF NEW YORK, 100 Church Street, New York, New York 10007; and P.O. MICHAEL PENA, Shield # 6176; DET. RICHARD MELEES, Shield # 4478; SGT. SHANNON BROOKS, Tax # 927964, Shield # 1365; UNDERCOVER OFFICER NUMBER 303; and P.O. JOHN DOES # 1-5, 13th Precinct, 230 E 21st St, New York, NY 10010, and/or One Police Plaza, New York, New York 10007

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Plaintiff Demetrius Burke, by and through his counsel, Michael O. Hueston, Esq.,
upon information and belief, alleges as follows:

PRELIMINARY STATEMENT

1. This is a civil rights, common law, and tort action in which plaintiff seeks relief for the violation of plaintiff's rights secured by 42 U.S.C. § 1983; and the Fourth, Sixth, and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution; and the laws of the State of New York. Plaintiff's claims arise from an incident that arose on or about April 26, 2016. During the incident, the City of New York, and members of the New York City Police Department ("NYPD") subjected plaintiff to, among other things: unlawful search and seizure; false arrest; assault; battery; unreasonable force; failure to intervene; malicious prosecution; denial of a fair trial/fabricated evidence; implementation and continuation of an unlawful municipal policy, practice, and custom; and respondeat superior liability. Plaintiff seeks compensatory and

punitive damages, declaratory relief, an award of costs and attorney's fees, pursuant 42 U.S.C. § 1988, and such other and further relief as the Court deems just and proper.

JURISDICTION & VENUE

2. Within 90 days of the incident alleged in this complaint, plaintiff served upon defendant City of New York a Notice of Claim setting forth the name and post office addresses of plaintiff, the nature of the claims, the time when, the place where and the manner in which the claims arose, and the items of damages or injuries claimed.

3. More than 30 days have elapsed since plaintiff's demands and/or claims were presented to defendant City of New York for adjustment and/or payment thereof, and the defendant has neglected and/or refused to make any adjustment and/or payment. Plaintiff has testified at a 50-H hearing.

4. Plaintiff has satisfied all conditions precedent for the filing of this action. This action is being commenced within one year and ninety days of the date of the occurrence herein.

5. Venue is proper in the Supreme Court of the State New York, New York County, because the acts in question occurred in the State of New York, New York County, and the City of New York is subject to personal jurisdiction in Supreme Court of the State New York, New York County; and jurisdiction is proper because the Supreme Court of the State New York, New York County has jurisdiction over plaintiff's state law causes of actions, and plaintiff's federal causes of action pursuant to 42 U.S.C. § 1983.

PARTIES

6. Plaintiff Demetrius Burke is a resident of the State of New York, living at 700 Quincy Street, Apt. # 1A, Brooklyn, New York, 11221.

7. At all times herein, defendant City of New York is a municipal corporation organized under the laws of the State of New York, which violated plaintiff's rights as described herein.

8. At all times relevant, defendant City of New York maintained a police department known as the NYPD, which employed the individual defendants.

9. At all times alleged herein, defendants P.O. Michael Pena, Shield # 6176; Det. Richard Melees, Shield # 4478; Sgt. Shannon Brooks, Tax # 927964, Shield # 1365; Undercover Officer Number 303; and P.O. John Does # 1-5; were employed as police officers with the 13th Precinct and/or Narcotics Borough Manhattan South, located in New York County, New York, or other as yet unknown NYPD assignment, who violated plaintiff's rights as described herein.

10. The individual defendants are sued in their individual and official capacities.

STATEMENT OF FACTS

The Incident

11. On April 26, 2016, at and in the vicinity of 109 East 16th Street, New York, New York, several police officers operating from the 13th Precinct and/or Narcotics Borough Manhattan South located in New York County, New York, including upon information and belief, the individual defendants P.O. Michael Pena, Shield # 6176; Det. Richard Melees, Shield # 4478; Sgt. Shannon Brooks, Tax # 927964, Shield # 1365; Undercover Officer Number 303; and P.O. John Does # 1-5 ("the police"), at times acting in concert and at times acting independently, committed the following illegal acts against plaintiff.

12. On April 26, 2016 at approximately 4:00 p.m., at and in the vicinity of 109 East 16th Street, New York, New York, the police without either consent, an arrest warrant, a lawful search warrant, probable cause, or reasonable suspicion that plaintiff had committed a crime unlawfully arrested plaintiff.

13. Plaintiff was working as a security guard for a private firm that supplies security for the City of New York, Human Resource Administration's office located at 109 East 16th Street, New York, New York.

14. Plaintiff was dressed in his security uniform.

15. Plaintiff was at his post in lobby, standing on a podium, talking to his firm's account manager and two police officers working for the Human Resource Administration.

16. While plaintiff was talking, the police pursued another individual into the lobby of the building.

17. The police were just steps behind this individual.

18. The police were in plain clothes.

19. The police did not have their weapons drawn and did not show any insignia identifying themselves at that time.

20. The individual said to plaintiff, in words and effect: *Hold this for me.*

21. At the same moment, the individual put something into plaintiff's pocket.

22. Plaintiff had no idea what this individual was doing or that the police were involved.

23. This individual often sells cigarettes at the location.

24. The police then said, in words and effect: *I saw him put money in your pocket.*

25. The police then grabbed plaintiff and placed him handcuffs.

26. The handcuffs were excessively tight.

27. The police removed what the individual had placed in plaintiff's pocket, which was United States currency.

28. Plaintiff, his account manager, and two HRA police officers protested the police's actions, asking the police what they were doing, and told the police that plaintiff had done nothing wrong and was not a criminal.

29. Plaintiff's account manager and two HRA police officers told the police that plaintiff was not involved with the individual, worked as a security guard (which was obvious from his uniform), and had done nothing illegal.

30. The individual who placed the currency in plaintiff's pocket also told the police that plaintiff was not involved with him and had done nothing illegal.

31. The police ignored the account manager, the HRA police officers, and the individual's remarks and assertions to them about plaintiff.

32. Instead, the police took plaintiff outside the lobby onto the street in handcuffs.

33. The police told the account manager, and the HRA police officers not come outside when they continued to speak to police on plaintiff's behalf.

34. Plaintiff complained about the tightness of the handcuffs and the conduct of the police.

35. The police placed plaintiff into a police vehicle with the other individual.

36. Plaintiff remained in the van for three hours before the police transported plaintiff the 13th Precinct for processing.

37. The individual continued to tell police that plaintiff was not involved.

38. The police transported plaintiff to Manhattan Central Booking for arraignment.

39. Plaintiff was detained at Central Booking.

40. In order to cover up their illegal actions, the police, pursuant to a conspiracy, initiated by false sworn complaint(s) and/or conversations, falsely and maliciously told the New York County District Attorney's Office that plaintiff had committed various crimes, including criminal sale of marijuana; and the District Attorney prosecuted plaintiff for various crimes.

41. Plaintiff was released at arraignment on his own recognizance.

42. All the criminal charges against plaintiff were dismissed on July 27, 2016, and the criminal case against plaintiff terminated in plaintiff's favor.

43. Plaintiff was humiliated and embarrassed by the experience.

44. Plaintiff suffered financial loss.

General Allegations

45. Plaintiff did not resist arrest at any time during the above-described incidents.

46. Plaintiff did not violate any law, regulation, or administrative code; commit any criminal act; or act in a suspicious or unlawful manner prior to or during the above-described incident.

47. The individual defendants did not observe plaintiff violate any law, regulation, or administrative code; commit any criminal act; or act in a suspicious or unlawful manner prior to or during the above-described incident.

48. The individual defendants acted under pretense and color of state law and their individual and official capacities and within the scope of their employment. Said acts by said defendants were beyond the scope of their jurisdiction, without authority or law, and in abuse of their powers, and said defendants acted willfully, knowingly, and with the specific intent to deprive plaintiff of his rights.

49. As a direct and proximate result of defendants' actions, plaintiff experienced personal and physical injuries, pain and suffering, fear, an invasion of privacy, psychological pain, emotional distress, mental anguish, embarrassment, humiliation, and financial loss.

50. Plaintiff is entitled to receive punitive damages from the individual defendants because the individual defendants' actions were motivated by extreme recklessness and indifference to plaintiff's rights.

FIRST CLAIM

(UNLAWFUL SEARCH AND SEIZURE UNDER FEDERAL LAW)

51. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

52. Defendants unlawfully searched and seized plaintiff without a lawful warrant, cause, consent, and/or beyond the scope of any warrant.

53. Accordingly, defendants are liable to plaintiff for unlawful search and seizure under 42 U.S.C. § 1983; and the Fourth and Fifth Amendments to the United States Constitution.

SECOND CLAIM

(UNLAWFUL SEARCH AND SEIZURE UNDER STATE LAW)

54. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

55. Defendants unlawfully searched and seized plaintiff without a lawful warrant, cause, consent, and/or beyond the scope of any warrant.

56. Accordingly, defendants are liable to plaintiff for unlawful search and seizure under New York State law.

THIRD CLAIM

(FALSE ARREST UNDER FEDERAL LAW)

57. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

58. Defendants falsely arrested plaintiff without consent, an arrest warrant, probable cause, or reasonable suspicion that plaintiff had committed a crime.

59. Accordingly, defendants are liable to plaintiff for false arrest under 42 U.S.C. § 1983; and the Fourth Amendment to the United States Constitution.

FOURTH CLAIM

(FALSE ARREST UNDER STATE LAW)

60. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

61. Defendants falsely arrested plaintiff without consent, an arrest warrant, probable cause, or reasonable suspicion that plaintiff had committed a crime.

62. Accordingly, defendants are liable to plaintiff for false arrest under New York State law.

FIFTH CLAIM

(UNREASONABLE FORCE)

63. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

64. The individual defendants' use of force upon plaintiff was objectively unreasonable.

65. The individual defendant officers did not have an objective and/or reasonable basis to use any degree of force against plaintiff.

66. Those defendants who did not touch plaintiff, witnessed these acts, but failed to intervene and protect plaintiff from this conduct.

67. Accordingly, the defendants are liable to plaintiff for using unreasonable force, pursuant to 42 U.S.C. § 1983; and the Fourth Amendment to the United States Constitution.

SIXTH CLAIM

(ASSAULT)

68. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

69. Among other things as described above, individual defendants' battery, false arrest, and unreasonable use of force against plaintiff placed him in fear of imminent harmful and offensive physical contacts.

70. Accordingly, defendants are liable to plaintiff under New York State law for assault.

SEVENTH CLAIM

(BATTERY)

71. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

72. Among other things as described above, the individual defendants' false arrest, and unreasonable use of force against plaintiff were illegal physical contacts.

73. Accordingly, defendants are liable to plaintiff under New York State law for battery.

EIGHTH CLAIM

(FAILURE TO INTERVENE)

74. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

75. Defendants had a reasonable opportunity to prevent the violations of plaintiff's constitutional rights, but they failed to intervene.

76. Accordingly, the defendants are liable to plaintiff for failing to intervene to prevent the violation of plaintiff's constitutional rights under 42 U.S.C. § 1983; and the Fourth Amendment to the United States Constitution.

NINTH CLAIM**(MALICIOUS PROSECUTION FEDERAL LAW)**

77. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

78. The individual defendants are liable to plaintiff for malicious prosecution because, pursuant to a conspiracy and acting with malice, the defendants initiated a malicious prosecution(s) against plaintiff by knowingly, intentionally, and maliciously providing false statements in complaints and police reports to police officers, prosecutors and/or the court(s), which alleged plaintiff had committed various crimes.

79. The individual defendants lacked probable cause to believe the above-stated malicious prosecution could succeed.

80. The individual defendants initiated the above-stated malicious prosecution to cover up their illegal and unconstitutional conduct.

81. The above-stated malicious prosecution caused a sufficient post-arraignment liberty restraint on plaintiff.

TENTH CLAIM**(DENIAL OF A FAIR TRIAL/FABRICATION OF EVIDENCE)**

82. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

83. The individual defendants are liable to plaintiff because they intentionally conspired to fabricate evidence against plaintiff, including omitting and/or manipulating evidence, and suppressing exculpatory evidence and forwarded that false evidence to police officers, prosecutors, and the court.

84. The individual defendants violated the law by either testifying falsely, providing false information, and/or drafting and signing false criminal court complaints and/or false police reports and forwarding them to police officers, prosecutors and the court.

85. The individual defendants were on notice that creating fabricated evidence is a clear violation of law because it is well established that individuals who knowingly use false evidence to obtain a conviction act unconstitutionally, depriving plaintiff of liberty without due process of law or a fair trial, and the harm occasioned by such unconscionable actions are redressable in an action for damages under 42 U.S.C. § 1983, the Fair Trial Clause of the Sixth Amendment to the United States Constitution, and the Due Process Clause of the Fourteenth Amendment to the United States Constitution.

ELEVENTH CLAIM

(MONELL CLAIM)

86. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

87. Defendant City of New York, through a policy, practice and custom, directly caused the constitutional violations suffered by plaintiff.

88. Defendant City of New York through the NYPD and its officers, committed the following unconstitutional practices, customs and policies against plaintiff: (1) arresting innocent persons in order to meet productivity goals and without cause; (2) using unreasonable force on individuals; and (3) fabricating evidence against innocent persons.

89. Upon information and belief, defendant City of New York, at all relevant times, was aware that the defendants were unfit officers who have previously committed the acts alleged herein, have a propensity for unconstitutional conduct, or have been inadequately trained.

90. Nevertheless, defendant City of New York exercised deliberate indifference by failing to take remedial action. The City failed to properly train, retrain, supervise, discipline, and monitor the individual defendants and improperly retained and utilized them. Moreover, upon information and belief, defendant City of New York failed to adequately investigate prior complaints filed against the individual defendants.

91. Further, defendant City of New York was aware prior to the incident that the individual defendants (in continuation of its illegal custom, practice and/or policy) would stop, arrest and prosecute innocent individuals, based on pretexts and false evidence.

92. The existence of the aforesaid unconstitutional customs and policies may be inferred from repeated occurrences of similar wrongful conduct involving the individual defendants, placing the defendant City of New York on notice of the individual defendants' propensity to violate the rights of individuals.

93. The foregoing customs, policies, usages, practices, procedures and rules of the City of New York and the NYPD were the moving force behind the constitutional violations suffered by plaintiff as alleged herein.

94. The City's failure to act resulted in the violation of plaintiff's constitutional rights as described herein.

TWELFTH CLAIM

(RESPONDEAT SUPERIOR)

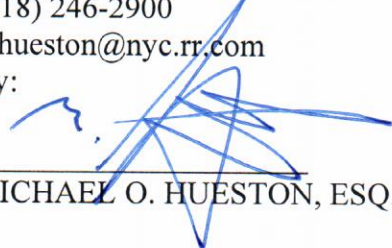
95. Plaintiff repeats and realleges all the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

96. The individual defendants were acting within the scope of their employment when they committed the above described acts against plaintiff, including falsely arresting, assaulting, and battering plaintiff.

97. The City of New York is therefore vicariously liable under New York State law for the aforesaid torts.

WHEREFORE, plaintiff demands a jury trial and the following relief jointly and severally against the defendants; and demands judgment and compensatory damages, individually and/or collectively in an amount that exceeds the jurisdiction of all lower courts that would otherwise have jurisdiction as to the above-stated cause of action against all defendants; punitive damages in an amount to be determined at trial as and for the above-stated causes of action against the individual defendants; together with costs and disbursements of this action and legal fees pursuant to 42 U.S.C. § 1988.

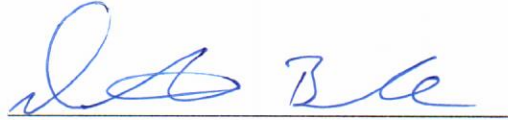
DATED: Brooklyn, New York
June 28, 2017

MICHAEL O. HUESTON, ESQ.
Attorney for Plaintiff
16 Court Street, Suite 3301
Brooklyn, New York 11241
(718) 246-2900
mhueston@nyc.rr.com
By: 

MICHAEL O. HUESTON, ESQ.

VERIFICATION

I, DEMETRIUS BURKE, state under the oath, that I am the deponent in this action, and that I have read the Verified Complaint and that it is true to the knowledge of the deponent, except as to matters, alleged on information and belief, and that as to those matters I believe it to be true.



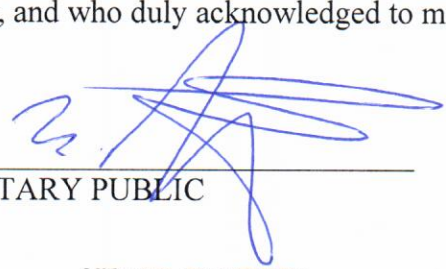
DEMETRIUS BURKE

STATE OF NEW YORK)

: ss:

COUNTY OF KINGS)

On the 28th day of June, 2017, before me personally came and appeared DEMETRIUS BURKE to me known and known to me to be the individual described in and who executed the foregoing instrument, and who duly acknowledged to me that he executed the same.



NOTARY PUBLIC

MICHAEL O HUESTON
Notary Public, State of New York
No. 02HU6073603
Qualified in Kings County
Commission Expires April 22, 2018

Index No.

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF NEW YORK

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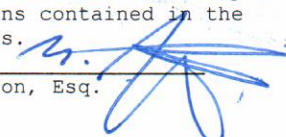
CITY OF NEW YORK, et al.,

Defendants.

SUMMONS AND VERIFIED COMPLAINT

MICHAEL O. HUESTON, ESQ.
Attorney for Plaintiff
16 Court St., Suite 3301
Brooklyn, New York 11241
(718) 246-2900

Pursuant to 22 NYCRR 130-1.1, the undersigned, an attorney duly admitted to practice law in the State of New York, certifies that, upon information and belief based upon reasonable inquiry, the contentions contained in the annexed document are not frivolous.

Dated: 6/28/2017 Signature: 

Michael O. Hueston, Esq.

*Due and timely, service is hereby
admitted.*

Brooklyn, New York....., 2017

....., Esq.

Attorney for.....